Standard Operating Procedure
BU3 – Vacuum cleaning

The candidate will be asked to vacuum clean an area of floor 10m^2 (including a corner and edge).

Health and Safety compliance

Demonstrate an understanding of the appropriate documentation:

Task Risk Assessment (RA)
Method Statement (MS) or Standard Operating Procedure (SOP)
Manufacturer's Operating Instructions

- The candidate should be able to identify the relevant information in the correct Task Risk Assessment, Method Statement/SOP, Manufacturer's Operating Instructions.

Recommended equipment

Warning signs
Appropriate personal protective equipment (PPE), as specified by task risk assessment
Vacuum cleaner and attachments
Circuit breaker (if applicable)
Colour-coded cloths
Colour-coded dustpan and brush – litter pickers are optional for large debris
Refuse bag

Procedure – Health and Safety considerations

1. Carry out a dynamic risk assessment on arrival at the work area and place warning signs

   - A dynamic risk assessment ensures the candidate is safe to work in the area as it demonstrates it is free from any immediate risks. Place warning signs to provide adequate warning of work in the area, this could include a sluice room, cleaning cupboard, cleaning store, preparation area as well as the work area.

2. Demonstrate an understanding of the standard operating procedure or method statement, risk assessment and manufacturer's machinery operating instructions

3. Wash your hands as per the company policy or according to the BICSc approved method, ensuring that you check for cuts and abrasions and cover with a waterproof dressing if required

   - Cuts or abrasions should be covered with a waterproof dressing to prevent cleaning solutions and bacteria entering the blood stream and potentially causing blood poisoning.

4. Check and wear PPE as per task risk assessment

   - Ensure PPE is a suitable fit, fit for purpose and undamaged.

5. Confirm all necessary colour-coded equipment is available and fit for purpose

   - Correct colour-coded equipment reduces the potential risk of cross-contamination and ensures demonstratable best working practices.

   - Check if the power supply within the building requires the use of a circuit breaker. If a circuit breaker is required check that the unit switches on and off correctly.

   - Safety check each part of the electrical equipment as appropriate.

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- Cables should be checked for exposed wires, cuts or scrapes by running a clean colour-coded cloth appropriate for the area the machine works in over it from the machine to the plug. Faulty equipment should be reported in line with company procedure.

- The cable should be neatly placed and should at no time present a trip hazard.

- Bags should be carefully lifted by one corner to check how full they are, it is not acceptable to press down on the bag as this could result in a sharps injury, or to cause dust showers when the check is made. A bag 2/3 full or more should be changed as this could put strain on the motor.

- The pipes and hose can be checked for blockage when the machine is switched on by checking the suction of the machine.

- The casing of the machine should be free from damage that would impair performance. The wheels should be free-moving.

- Ensure the correct accessories are selected, a vacuum cleaner should have the relevant tools required to complete the skill.

- Check that the portable appliance test complies with the company policy.

6. Check the area where you are working for any signs of pest infestation and report them in line with company policy

    - Signs of pest infestation should be checked in the cleaning cupboard/store and throughout the task in the work area but must not be disturbed as the pest control company will use this evidence to identify the type of infestation.

7. Check the area where you are working for any signs of damage and report them in line with company policy

    - Damaged assets such as broken tiles, torn/snagged carpet, chipped desks in either the cleaning cupboard/store or work area should be reported as per company policy to prevent any further damage and/or the operative being blamed for the damage.

Procedure – Method

8. Commence the skill by removing large items of debris and/or adhesive soiling

    - Remove any large items of debris and/or adhesive soiling from the floor with a dustpan, brush and scraper. Place in the refuse bag and position the refuse bag carefully to avoid becoming a trip hazard.

9. Select the vacuum setting applicable to the area being cleaned

    - Brushes should be used for hard floor coverings and retracted for soft floor coverings.

10. Connect the vacuum cleaner to the power supply

    - The candidate should demonstrate the safe method of plugging in electrical equipment with the socket switched off and always with dry hands.

    - Use a socket behind the line of work and as close to the exit as possible to minimise trip hazards and ensuring the cable is behind the line of work.

    - Avoiding standing on the cable is primarily for the operative's safety. It is possible that something sharp on the sole of a shoe could cut through the wire. Ensure the candidate is aware that it is with their wellbeing in mind that this is stressed as a safety point.

11. Commence cleaning the floor using the appropriate tool for the edge(s) and corner(s)

    - Use the vacuum cleaner accessories to thoroughly clean the edges of the floor in manageable sized areas.

12. Continue to clean the manageable areas using systematic overlapping passes

- Starting at the closest point to the power supply, cleaning should continue working away from the power socket to avoid the risk of tripping over the cable and to avoid damaging the cable by overstretching it and potentially pulling the plug out of the socket.

- This ensures the cable is behind the operative and avoids accidental damage to the cable by not coming into contact with the vacuum head.

- Extra attention should be paid to traffic lanes.

- Traffic lanes are only present on soft flooring. They are generally found at entrance/exit points and under desks. Cleaning in both directions over these areas removes the excess grit that, if left, could damage the carpet over time.

- Whilst not in use the machine should be switched off on the unit and at the power socket, unplugged and placed in an area so that it does not become an obstruction for people using the building.

Procedure – Safe storage of equipment

13. Demonstrate the correct cleaning and storage method for equipment, materials and PPE used for the skill

    - Storage should allow for air circulation when storing equipment to aid drying and for gas dispersal if battery equipment is used.

    - Where laundry facilities are available candidates should follow the agreed company procedure.

    - When the safety checks are carried out at the completion of the skill this is the ideal time to change the vacuum bag, if required, as it can then be disposed of as part of the waste. The checks also ensure that if the machine has been damaged while in use it can be reported according to the site's procedure and no other operatives are put at risk.

14. Remove warning signs, clean as required before storing safely

    - Best practice is to clean warning signs after each use to reduce the potential risk of cross-contamination.

15. Remove PPE and wash your hands as per the company policy or according to the BICSc approved method

16. The storage area must be left in a clean, tidy and secure condition on exit

    - Good sustainable practice would be to turn off the lights and air conditioning, if applicable, prior to securing the storage area.